

NEVER AN ADEYEMI

EPISODE 5: THE WITNESS

PALMFIRE SEASON 1

Screenplay draft

Based on Mario's final story brief and story bible

Contemporary Lagos romance with stakes

FADE IN:

EXT. IBADAN CHURCH GUESTHOUSE - EVENING

Rain darkens the courtyard. Tobi stands beneath the guesthouse awning with Mrs. Aina's address.

CARETAKER

Mr. Afolabi left three months ago.

TOBI

Where did he go?

CARETAKER

He collected letters at the cathedral post office.

TOBI

Did he leave a forwarding address?

CARETAKER

He left a box of books and a bill.

Tobi calls the number written on the bill. It rings once, then cuts.

TOBI

My name is Tobi Adeyemi. I am not calling on behalf of my family.

CUT TO:

INT. IBADAN CATHEDRAL POST OFFICE - NEXT MORNING

A POSTMASTER flips through a register thick with old signatures.

POSTMASTER

Afolabi collected mail here, but he stopped signing.

TOBI

He left a letter for Obinna Obi.

POSTMASTER

That name is not common in this book.

He removes a sealed envelope from a drawer.

POSTMASTER

He asked me to destroy it. I did neither.

TOBI

Why give it to me?

POSTMASTER

You came twice.

Tobi turns the envelope over. The seal is unbroken.

CUT TO:

INT. AFOLABI'S MODEST FLAT - LAGOS - NIGHT

The door opens. EMMANUEL AFOLABI, late seventies, looks at Tobi and the envelope.

AFOLABI

You came alone.

TOBI

I did.

AFOLABI

That is not the same as coming without your family.

TOBI

I left them behind.

Afolabi lets him in. Old files line one wall.

TOBI

My father says the deed was forged.

AFOLABI

Your father always had the truth. He lacked the paper that made powerful men afraid of it.

TOBI

You saw the paper.

AFOLABI

I saw a copied signature. I saw my senior partner tell me to stop asking why.

TOBI

Why did you leave?

AFOLABI

The law was being used to make theft look patient.

CUT TO:

INT. AFOLABI'S MODEST FLAT - CONTINUOUS

Afolabi opens a file and removes a draft letter addressed to Chief Adeyemi.

AFOLABI

Chief wrote this with me. He wanted to admit what his father had done.

TOBI

Why was it never sent?

AFOLABI

Courage is often delayed by the people it would hurt.

TOBI

He put a forty-percent offer in the will.

AFOLABI

That was the first decision nobody could talk him out of.

TOBI

Will you testify?

AFOLABI

I will tell the truth about what I saw. I will not rescue your family from its consequences.

TOBI

I am not asking you to rescue anyone.

AFOLABI

Good. That is the first thing you have said that sounds like your father.

Afolabi signs the last page as a witness to his account.

CUT TO:

EXT. LAGOS ROAD - NIGHT

Tobi rides home through wet traffic. He calls MRS. EZE, the estate solicitor.

MRS. EZE (V.O.)

A copy can still be material if its source is identified.

TOBI

My family destroyed the original.

MRS. EZE (V.O.)

Then record what they prevented the estate from seeing.

TOBI

They will say this is a family dispute.

MRS. EZE (V.O.)

The historic ownership question is civil. The living acts may be separate.

Tobi looks at Afolabi's signed statement in the passenger seat.

CUT TO:

INT. OBI FAMILY HOME - NIGHT

Mr. Obi reads the statement. Ify stands behind him, listening.

MR. OBI

You found him.

TOBI

He found a way to be found.

MR. OBI

What are you asking me to do?

TOBI

Make a report about the waiver and the destroyed evidence.

MR. OBI

If I accept the shares, they will call me greedy.

IFY

They will call you that whether you accept or reject.

MR. OBI

The old forgery will not become a criminal case because we found an old lawyer.

TOBI

I know. The truth can still be heard.

A car stops outside. Kunle's silhouette crosses the curtain with a brown envelope.

MR. OBI

He has come early.

IFY

For what?

Kunle knocks once. No one moves.

FADE OUT.